

The Glorious King of Tantras, the King of Passion

Śrī Rāgarāja Tantra Rāja · Toh 405 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ཆགས་པའི་རྒྱ་པོའི་རྒྱུད་ཀྱི་རྒྱལ་པོ་

The Glorious King of Tantras, the King of Glorious Passion — known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Rāgarāja Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as Dpal chags pa'i rgyal po'i rgyud kyi rgyal po — is a Buddhist tantric scripture belonging to the Kangyur, where it is catalogued as Toh 405. It is a tantra text in which the Blessed One, dwelling in union with the Vajra Queen, responds to the bodhisattva Vajragarbha's questions concerning the buddha-nature of sentient beings, their major and minor marks, and the various modes of birth and liberation. The text opens with homage to the Glorious Vajra Ḍākinī, immediately signaling its orientation within the Vajrayāna tradition and its concern with esoteric teachings on enlightened body, speech, and mind shared by all tathāgatas. As a tantra of this character — combining devotional, cosmological, and soteriological themes framed within a dialogue between teacher and bodhisattva — it belongs to the broader class of tantric works preserved in the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Śrī Rāgarāja Tantra Rāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious King of Tantras, the King of Glorious Passion. Homage to the Glorious Vajra Ḍākinī.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, dwelt within the bhaga of the noble Vajra Queen, he who is the vajra body, speech, and mind of all tathāgatas. Then the bodhisattva, the great being Vajragarbha, having made offerings with incense, flowers, and the like, spoke:

Hé hé, great hero, great and fearsome one,
tell me of sentient beings' buddha-nature:
the major and minor marks, each and every one,
the thousand, liberation in its forms,
birth by miraculous apparition, by womb, by egg,
by warmth and moisture — how do all two, three, and four apply?

The Blessed One then declared:

A is the uṣṇīṣa at the crown of the head.

Ā is the hair turning to the right.

I is the even parting at the brow.

Ī is the ūrṇā between the brows.

U is the dark-blue iris of the eye,
like the pupil that rests within it.

Ū possesses forty teeth.

Ṛ and Ṝ: the teeth are even, the gaps are fine.

Ḷ and Ḹ: the teeth are white, superlative in their whiteness.

E is the cheeks like a lion's.

Ai is the tongue, exceedingly slender.

O possesses the voice of Brahmā.

Au is the shoulder-tops, perfectly round.

Om̐: seven prominences are proclaimed.

Aḥ is the chest, broad and full.

These sixteen turn to the right.

Then, reckoning from where the left-turning ones begin:

A is skin that is thin and of golden hue.

Ā is the quality that, while one stands, the hands without bowing reach the knees.

I is the torso's upper body, like a lion's.

Ī is like the nyagrodha tree: the span of the arms and the height are equal, concealed one within the other.

U is the ūrṇā turning to the right.

Ū is the body-hairs, each pointing upward.

Ṛ: the hollow of the navel sinks inward.

Ṝ: the thighs are beautifully round.

Ḷ: the ankle-bones are not prominent.

Ḹ: the hands and feet are soft and tender.

Ḹ: the palms and soles of the feet are soft, tender, and well-fleshed.

E: the hands and feet are joined by webbing.

Ai: the nails are long.

O: the palms of the hands and the soles of the feet bear the wheel-marks.

Au: the feet are most perfectly placed.

Om̐: the heels are broad.

Aḥ: the calves are like those of an antelope, like those of the eṇa deer.

At the crown is the indestructible essence: Hūṃ.

These are the thirty-two marks of the Teacher.

Ka: the nails are of copper hue.
Kha: the nails are lustrous in color.
Ga: the nails are high and prominent.
Gha: the fingers are round.
Ṇa: the fingers are full and plump.
Ca: the lower legs are delicately shaped.
Cha: the veins are not prominent.
Ja: the veins have no knots.
Jha: the ankle-hollows are not prominent.
Ña: there is no unevenness in the feet.
Ṭa: the gait is like that of a lion.
Ṭha: the gait is like that of an elephant.
Ḍa: the gait is like that of a goose.
Ḍha: the gait is like that of a supreme bull.
Ṇa: the gait turns toward the left side.
Ta: the gait is beautiful.
Tha: the gait is unhurried and steady.
Da: the body bears the imprint of graceful deportment.
Dha: the body is as though freshly bathed.
Na: the body is proportionate throughout.
Pa: the body is pure; the complexion is soft.
Ba: the body is perfectly pure.
Bha: the marks are perfect in their nature.
Ma: the body's chest is broad and fine.
Ya: the steps are even.
Ra: the body has a complexion exceedingly youthful.
La: there is no confusion or disorder in the body.
Va: the body and frame are full and well-developed.
Śa: the body is most compact and firm.
Ṣa: all limbs are beautiful.
Sa: the gaze is clear, without any film, and pure.
Ha: the belly is perfectly round.
Kṣa: the flanks are divided at the midpoint.
Ya: the belly is even.
Ra: there is no flabbiness or looseness.
La: the navel is deep.
Va: the navel turns to the right.
Ḍha: beautiful from every side.

Dha: all conduct is pure.

These, by the nature of skillful means, make forty turning to the right.

Then the forty turning to the left:

Ka: the body has no unsightly dark moles.

Kha: the hands are soft like cotton wool.

Ga: the lines of the hands have luster.

Gha: the lines of the hands are deep.

Ña: the lines of the hands are long.

Ca: the face is not too long.

Cha: the form's reflection appears in the face.

Ja and Jha: the tongue is soft; the tongue is slender.

Ña: the tongue is red by nature.

Ṭa: the voice is like the roar of an elephant, like the sound of a dragon.

Ṭha: the voice is melodious, gentle, and soft.

Ḍa and Ḍha: the canine teeth are round and sharp.

Ṇa: the canines are white; the teeth are even.

Tha: the canines are subtly radiant.

Da: the cheekbones are very prominent.

Dha: the cheekbones are very clean.

Na: the eyes are perfectly pure in their radiance.

Pa and Pha: the eyes are beautiful, with dense lashes.

Ba: the eyes are lotus eyes, their luster like the petals of a lotus, half white and half dark.

Bha: likewise, the eyebrows are long.

Ma and Ya: the eyebrows are even; the hairs of the eyebrows are equal.

Ra: likewise, the eyebrows are glossy.

La: the arms are long and fully developed.

Likewise Va: the ears are even; the faculty of hearing is unimpaired.

Ṣa: the forehead is well divided.

Sa: the division of the forehead is broad.

Ha: the head is very fully developed.

Kṣa: the hair of the head is black like a swarm of bees.

Ya: the hair of the head is thick.

Likewise Ra: the hair of the head is soft.

Va: the hair of the head does not fall out.

Ḍa: the hair of the head is fragrant.

The hands are adorned with the auspicious emblem, the swastika spiraling with good fortune.

Ḍha: these are like tree-trunk markings.

Aṃ: the navel is the essence of emanation.

These complete the eighty minor marks.

A: emptiness of inner and outer.

Ā: emptiness of emptiness.

I: great emptiness.

Ī: ultimate emptiness.

U: emptiness of the conditioned.

Ū: emptiness of the unconditioned.

Ṛ: emptiness beyond extremes.

Ṛ: emptiness of beginning and end.

Ḷ: emptiness of non-rejection.

Ḷ: emptiness of intrinsic nature.

E: emptiness of all phenomena.

Ai: emptiness of their own defining characteristics.

O: emptiness of the non-apprehensible.

Au: emptiness of non-entities.

Aṃ: emptiness of essential nature.

Aḥ: emptiness of the essential nature of non-entities.

The throat is Om, essence of enjoyment.

Wisdom's sixteen root teachings:

One who has form contemplating forms — this is the first liberation, A.

One who perceives inner formlessness contemplating outer forms — this is the second liberation, Ka.

The full actualization of the beautiful liberation body — that is the third liberation, Ca.

Transcending the perception of form, not attending to diverse perceptions, dwelling in boundless space — Ṭa.

Transcending boundless space and dwelling in boundless consciousness, completing boundless consciousness — Ta.

Transcending boundless consciousness and dwelling in nothingness, completing that very nothingness — Pa.

Transcending nothingness, dwelling in neither-perception-nor-non-perception, completing neither-perception-nor-non-perception — Ya.

Transcending neither-perception-nor-non-perception, fully actualizing the body of the cessation of perception and feeling — this is the eighth liberation, Śa.

The heart is Hūṃ, the wheel of Dharma.

These principal ones are endowed with the eight liberations. These abide as the root arrangement. The seal of the wheel measures three finger-widths. It abides by nature in all sentient beings. Therefore sentient beings are buddhas by nature.

The characteristics that gather all variety extend far and rest briefly, like the hair between the eyebrows. At the navel, the source of phenomena, there are five channels to the right and five to the left, arising from the space between above and below. The rasanā channel faces openly to the east. The lalanā channel is to the west, the lower one. The rasanā embraces the lalanā, and in the right part they enter union. The lalanā embraces the rasanā, and in the left part they enter union. The tips on the right and left are body, speech, and mind. Those sounds are renowned as mantra. Mantras, tantras, and accomplishments and so forth all arise from that very reality. Thus sentient beings are buddhas by nature.

The sequence of the four births also dissolves into the father and mother as container and contents. Father and mother become sun and moon. Together with the bindus of appearance — these are the manner of inner womb-birth. The vowel series and consonant series are sun and moon. The mind abides in the nature of the bindu.

This too is held to be inner egg-birth. From kā and ā come sun and moon. The self-arisen bindu is warmth and moisture. These, arising from their intrinsic nature without conditions in a mere instant, constitute miraculous birth.

From the union without conditions — eggs and so forth — arise bliss and the cause of bliss. All of this is recalled as the secret manner of womb-birth.

Burning upward and nurturing downward, it moves through twenty-four sites in the three places. Through the outer and inner signs of desire, the channels expand and bestow bliss, and in the palace of the precious one the mind is held — this is secret egg-birth.

Through the inner weapon of desire, the arising of bliss is warmth-and-moisture birth. That which arises not through conditions but has from the very beginning arisen as the cause of bliss — that arising of bliss is miraculous birth.

Fierce inner heat (caṇḍālī) ignited by reversed conditions; fierce inner heat ignited by conditions; fierce inner heat ignited in reverse; and fierce inner heat ignited by its own intrinsic nature — these are to be applied in sequence to womb-birth, egg-birth, warmth-and-moisture birth, and miraculous birth.

With support and with many supports, without support and utterly without support — all four: womb-birth, egg-birth, warmth-and-moisture birth, and miraculous birth, are to be applied in sequence.

Cause and path and all fruit are one in the nature of the four births. Therefore buddhas and sentient beings, though their reality is of equal taste, go astray into duality through the illusion of mistaken thought.

Vajra Essence, Great Compassion — hear well as I now explain the inner and secret maṇḍalas. Meditate on the maṇḍala of the body at the crown. Speech is the throat, mind is the heart. Qualities are at the navel, and activity is to be contemplated at the tip of the nose.

At the A of the four blazings, Vajravārāhī is renowned. HŪṂ is held to be Cakrasaṃvara Heruka, the sole hero. The seventh and the ninth are renowned as arising from the third HŪṂ. The thirteenth and fifteenth are renowned as arising from OM. The twenty-fifth and twenty-ninth truly abide in the nature of HŪṂ. The thirty-seventh and sixty-fourth are definitively the maṇḍala of A.

The nāḍī is Vajravārāhī: right, left, and the palms — and the central channel is her face. The hero is bodhicitta. The purified essences of the twelve sense bases are renowned as the twelve hands. The purified essences of the four elements are definitively the four faces. Because they are beautiful, they are described as ornaments. Receive the supreme speech from the mouth of the guru.

Right, left, above, below — four gates, a square of equal measure to one armspan. The five nectars are the five pigments. The nāḍīs are by their nature lines. The eight pillars are the eight legs. Teeth, nails, hair, body hair, and so forth — the wise should examine and know these. These are the natural maṇḍala, like self-arisen gold by way of example. This is not fabricated.

The reflection of self-aware primordial wisdom — this reflection-maṇḍala is not something to be meditated upon as an image; it is not to be drawn with colored powder and the like; it is not to be worshipped with incense and so forth; one does not bow to gods made of stone or wood. The buddha abiding by intrinsic nature is always worshipped by offering in accordance with that intrinsic nature.

The body is winter — its intrinsic nature being three months, the three months of the arising body. Speech is spring — its essential nature being three months, the three months of the entering body. Mind is summer — its essential nature being three months, the three months of the abiding body. Primordial wisdom is the time of autumn — body, speech, and mind together being three months.

The first is the ground of cause. In the red wheel of formation, the syllables abide in white. Those of the path are of two kinds: distant and near. Following these comes the ground of fruit, the wheel of perfect abiding.

Those very wheels and their deities are utterly free from any color of body or hand-implement. Clear by intrinsic nature, stainless, lucid as crystal and without blemish — they have the nature of being seen by those who do not see. Profound and subtle by nature. Outwardly, the deities with bodily colors and hand-implements; inwardly, a form supremely subtle; and in the secret, definitively the deity of bliss.

From that, the deity of the fourth reversal:
Because it arises from the body, it is called deity.
Because it purifies the streams, it is deity.
Because of great attachment, it is deity.
The king is of the nature of wisdom;
the tantra of great attachment
is taught as the nature of method and wisdom.

Then the great earth shook mightily. A great rain of offering clouds fell. Then the heroes (vīras) and the ḍākinīs, joyful and delighted in the meaning of the tantra, rejoiced and vanished from sight.

The Tantra-King of the Glorious King of Attachment, the King of Tantras, is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The text is the opening of a tantra belonging to the Rāgarāja cycle, structured as a sūtra-style hearing narrative framing a tantric teaching on the Buddha's thirty-two major marks and eighty minor marks, here correlated systematically with the Sanskrit vowels and consonants. This is an unusual and highly technical genre.

The term "bhaga" in the opening is a Sanskrit loanword retained in the Tibetan and used technically in tantric contexts to denote the female consort's sacred center; it is left as "bhaga" in the translation as a standard technical term, consistent with the text's openly tantric register.

The lines on Ī regarding the nyagrodha tree describe the classic major mark in which the height of the body and the arm-span are equal, which is compared to the proportions of the banyan tree. The Tibetan reads "chu dang zheng ni gab pa" literally as the measurement of water and span being hidden or equal to one another; this is the standard mark and has been rendered accordingly.

The repeated Ī entry appears twice in the left-turning vowel section in the Tibetan, likely a scribal duplication or deliberate repetition for two sub-aspects of the same mark; both have been translated.

The phrase "eṇa" for the antelope simile uses the Sanskrit proper name of the deer species, retained for precision, as it is a standard canonical reference in descriptions of the Buddha's calf-mark.

- The passage is structured as a liturgical enumeration correlating Sanskrit syllables of the alphabet with the eighty minor marks of a great being and subsequently with the sixteen emptinesses and the eight liberations. The pairing of syllables with doctrinal categories follows tantric abhidharma conventions found in texts of the Vajrayāna corpus.

The terms rasanā and lalanā refer to the right and left subtle channels in tantric physiology and are kept in Sanskrit here as they are technical terms of the inner yogic anatomy that have no transparent English equivalent.

The phrase rendered "emptiness of non-rejection" for the syllable ḷ translates a term meaning literally "without turning away" or "without dismissal," indicating the emptiness that does not exclude or negate any phenomenon. This is a recognized but less commonly glossed entry in the standard list of sixteen or eighteen emptinesses.

The "auspicious emblem" and "swastika spiraling with good fortune" render the Tibetan terms for the śrīvatsa and the auspicious coiling svastika, both recognized minor marks; the passage lists them together in connection with the syllable Ḍha in the context of hand markings.

- The passage is a dense Vajrayāna inner-yoga text, likely from a Cakrasaṃvara or related Yoginītantra cycle, correlating the four births, the nāḍī-cakra system, and maṇḍala visualization with the seasons and stages of the path. The enumeration of specific numbers of syllables or cakra-petals (seventh, ninth, thirteenth, and so on) mapped to seed-syllables OM, HŪM, and A follows a numerical schema found in several Cakrasaṃvara commentarial traditions; the exact correspondence intended here may vary by lineage and is left as stated without harmonizing. The term rendered "fierce inner heat ignited in reverse" for gtuṃ mo go bzlog reflects a technical distinction within Vajrayāna praxis between standard and reversed modes of igniting caṇḍālī; the precise technical difference between the three modes listed is a matter of lineage instruction rather than public textual commentary.

- The phrase "deity of the fourth reversal" refers to a technical tantric schema, presumably elaborated earlier in the text, in which deities correspond to successive "reversals" or counter-movements within the subtle body or path. The precise doctrinal referent depends on

the broader tantra cycle to which this passage belongs and cannot be fully resolved from the passage alone.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.